

Results of “The 2010 American Pantry Study: The New Rules of the Shopping Game” concur. A joint project between Deloitte and Harrison Group was designed to quantify changes in consumer behavior and provide packaged-goods executives with an understanding of the new consumer. This study explored issues of post-recessionary purchasing resourcefulness and the impact on brands.

“We continue to witness consumers creating a whole new rule book and skill set for shopping that’s based on value, not boasting of brands,” said Pat Conroy, Deloitte’s vice-chairman. “Our analysis concludes that personal gratification and a desire to feel smart about what consumers are putting in their shopping carts are trumping brand satisfaction, and that price-consciousness, value orientation, and bargain hunting will remain prevalent for years to come.”

Even more telling, he continued, “This choice between brands heralds back to the consumer’s belief that the game is not necessarily about the savings itself, but about the hunt for the savings and what goes into it—resourcefulness, planning, and precision. Consumers have become so skilled in executing their new approaches that most feel they have become smarter, more calculating shoppers. Moreover, this new ‘badge of honor’ will not fade away.”

You’ve got that right, Mister. Avid couponers deserve a badge of honor. And that badge should come with a rebate, or at least a coupon for future purchases.

Wendy Liebmann, chief executive officer of WSL Strategic Retail, in a preview of its 2010 “How America Shops Mega Trends” study said it this